Incident report: webhook backlog after the 2026-03-12 outage

Document: INC-306

Date: 2026-03-13

Services: notifications

Summary

During the March 12, 2026 outage documented in INC-301, the notifications service experienced a significant backlog of merchant webhooks. As payment processing was disrupted, webhook events accumulated in the queue faster than the notification workers could process them. The backlog reached 26,900 webhooks before being cleared.

Impact

Merchants were unable to receive real-time webhook notifications about payment events during and after the outage. This delayed their ability to reconcile transactions, update order statuses, and trigger downstream business processes. The backlog persisted until notification workers were scaled up to handle the accumulated load.

Timeline

- 08:00 UTC: Outage begins; payment processing disrupted
- 14:30 UTC: Notifications team identifies webhook queue backlog
- 15:15 UTC: Change CHG-1045 approved for emergency scale-up of notification workers
- 16:30 UTC: Backlog cleared; all 26,900 webhooks processed

Root Cause

The notifications service was sized for normal payment throughput. When the outage in INC-301 disrupted payment processing, the rate of webhook events initially remained high while worker capacity was insufficient to process them. The queue grew unchecked until manual intervention scaled the workers.

Resolution

Hannah Kim and the Merchant Experience team executed CHG-1045, scaling notification workers from 8 to 24 instances. This increased processing capacity allowed the backlog to be cleared by 16:30 UTC. All queued webhooks were successfully delivered to merchants.

Follow-up Actions

- Review RB-07 for webhook backlog procedures and update if needed
- Implement auto-scaling rules for notification workers to prevent future backlogs during service disruptions
- Add monitoring alerts for webhook queue depth to enable faster detection